

1811–1820

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Fashions began to move in a new direction away from the narrow Empire line and into a softer bell shape, with fuller skirts. Though white still predominated, stronger dye colours were reintroduced for outer garments like pelisses and spencer jackets. Upper sleeves gained small puffs, and lower sleeves had longer cuffs. The English waistline had begun to move down a little c. 1808–14, but this did not last and it sprang back up to a high point when French fashions became accessible again after the Battle of Waterloo in 1815. Pintucking appeared on skirts as a decorative feature and went on to be used for lengthening and shortening skirts as hemlines changed. Vandyking (zigzag shaping) was a prevalent feature c. 1815–35 and satin stitch was popular. Original gowns that survive testify to the detail, ingenuity, and fineness of the designs and embroidery.

SHOPPING



Drapers, haberdashers, hosiers, and mercers supplied fine materials like gauze and trimmings for dressmakers and ladies who liked to trim their own dresses and bonnets, or give fashion items as presents. Milliners not only sold caps and ribbons, but also calico (cotton), jaconet (cotton muslin), cambric (linen), sarcenet (silk), and superfine fabrics, gloves, and lace. There were dyers who also cleaned clothes, with ox-gall and fuller's earth. Note the reticule (bag) on the lady's wrist.



1810

Rounded train Fabrics of woven silver tissue, muslin embroidered with silver foil, and printed cotton with small repeats were popular for evening dresses. The border pattern on the hem, cuffs, and collar coordinates with the main fabric of this gown.



1815

Dress with double hem ruffles

Greek key border motif

Ankles visible



Short puffed sleeves

Hair dressed with artificial flowers

Vandyked hem

Summer fashion Peace after the Napoleonic wars put a spring in the step of ladies of fashion. There was a buoyancy and frivolity about fashion designs, which began to feature decorative trims and ruffles. A parasol to keep off the sun completed this outfit.

Evening dress This evening dress with back outlined in chenille or ruffled ribbon demonstrates the ultrahigh waistline that returned from 1815 to 1817. The design, inspired by neoclassical decoration, featured in the April issue of the *Lady's Magazine*, a British fashion magazine.